company. I knew straight away I was crazy about Victoria. I found myself thinking about how and when I could be with her during most of every day we were apart. No sooner had we met, she'd had to jet off to America with the Spice Girls. We spent hour after hour talking and the bills got scarier and scarier. But they were the best investment I've ever made. The couple of times we'd actually been face to face, I'd felt so nervous it took my breath away. It's strange how different it was on the phone. It seemed to be the most natural thing in the world to be telling this amazing woman all about my life —and my feelings—and listening to her do the same. By the time she got back to England, it felt like we really knew each other. We started to find out, as well, what we were going to mean to each other. Whatever the phone company had made out of it seemed like a bargain.

The florists didn't do too badly by me, either. I sent flowers to each new hotel Victoria booked into and a single red rose every day for the best part of a month. I couldn't wait for her to come home. I think perhaps people have this idea that our life together must always have been about glamorous parties: stars, luxuries, photo opportunities. That couldn't be further from the truth. Having the time together was all that mattered. The first date had been about driving around, getting thrown out of a Chinese restaurant, and sitting on a friend's sofa. Our second evening out was just as low-key as the first. We arranged to meet up outside another pub—that's how stylish we were—this one called City Limits. A strange thing happened on the way there. I stopped at a petrol station and went in to buy some chewing gum. Just as I was pulling out of the lot, I saw Victoria arrive, jump out and do the same thing. Fresh breath, or something to steady the nerves? Both probably. I drove on to City Limits and parked.

When Victoria arrived, I jumped out, went over to her MG and got in beside her. For such a little car, I remember there was a big gap between the driver's and front passenger's seats. We didn't go anywhere. We talked. And we kissed, for the first time. I had a cut on my finger from training. Victoria reached across me to the glove compartment and pulled out this sprig of a plant, Aloe Vera.

'It'll heal you.'

She rubbed it on the cut and then gave it to me. I must have told her about getting hurt on the phone and she'd brought it along. I remember, a week or two later, looking in my fridge and seeing this Aloe Vera plant, starting to decompose in a bag on the shelf. By then, whatever magic it contained had already done its job. At the end of that evening in the parking lot at City